# From intermediate to advanced

Hello everyone, and welcome to innerFrench!

[00:00:17] Yes, a new name and a new jingle! The Cottongue Podcast is over. I decided to change all that because it wasn't very clear. Some people couldn't find me on Google. Now I hope it will be easier. In any case, I'm very happy to present this new version of my podcast to you. Don't worry, my goal is still the same: to help you learn French naturally.

[00:00:55] If you've listened to the previous episodes, you already know the principle, the idea behind this podcast. Every week, I talk to you about a new subject that I find interesting, and I try to explain it simply. Subjects relating to French culture, current events, history, science, psychology, personal development, and so on. That way, you can get used to listening to spoken, oral language. I hope this helps you improve your comprehension, to understand French better. And if you don't understand everything, the transcript of each episode is available on my website. By the way, the website's new address is: innerfrench.com. Remember that address and go and visit the new website when you have a minute to spare.

[00:02:09] This can also help you work on your pronunciation by listening to me and repeating what I say. In my opinion, it's a very good exercise because, by doing that, you get used to speaking French. If you do it often enough, it will become easier and easier, and more natural. You can also record yourself, record your voice with a microphone or with your mobile phone. That way, you'll be able to see how you're developing and the progress you're making!

[00:02:56] By the way, if you have suggestions for subjects, topics you'd like me to talk about, don't hesitate to write to me. Send me an email at hugo@innerfrench.com to say: “Hey Hugo, can you do a podcast about French cinema or cooking?” Because if it's a subject that interests you, there's a good chance it will interest other listeners too. So I'll be very happy to talk about it!

[00:03:38] As it happens, a week ago I received an email from a listener. Listen to what she wrote to me.

[00:03:50] “Hi Hugo,

My name is Giulia. I'm Italian, but I've been working in the United States for four years. I live in Houston, Texas, where there is currently a storm and where many people have had to leave their homes because of these weather conditions. Experts say that this event is a real catastrophe.

Fortunately, where I live, the rain hasn't caused any major damage. I just have to stay at home and not take the risk of going out.

It's an unfortunate event, and I hope it will end soon. I'm writing to tell you that I've had a lot of time to devote to your podcasts and that I particularly enjoyed the ones about French education and Uber. This morning, too, I listened to a radio programme about Uber and its new CEO. It's a very interesting subject that's constantly evolving.

I studied French in middle school and high school, but I gave it up after the Baccalauréat. I decided to start practising it again for two reasons. The first is that I love foreign languages and I love speaking them: it's very good mental exercise! The second is that I'm looking for work in Geneva, Switzerland, and I'd like to improve my ability to communicate with the people who live in that city.

Please forgive my vocabulary and grammar mistakes. My keyboard is American, and that doesn't help!

Thank you for your help. I appreciate it very much: your podcasts are not only useful, but they're also really very interesting.

See you soon,
Giulia”

[00:06:11] Thank you very much for your email, Giulia. Of course, I've been following what happened with Hurricane Harvey, and I'm very sad for everyone who was affected by it. I know that many of our American friends listen to this podcast, so I'd like to take this opportunity to tell them that they're very much in my thoughts, particularly those who are in the states affected by the storm. I know it will take time to repair the damage, and that some of it is irreparable, but I also know that you'll have the courage to do it.

[00:06:56] Giulia, as for you, I hope you find a job in Geneva. In any case, your French seems excellent, so I'm sure you won't have any trouble talking to French-speaking Swiss people! Thank you again for your compliments. Receiving this kind of email makes me very happy and motivates me to continue my podcasts to help you.

[00:07:25] Right, without further ado, let's move on to the main subject of this episode.

[00:07:38] Today, I'm going to give you some advice on making progress in French, on moving from the intermediate level to the advanced level. When you're learning a language, there are different plateaus, different times when you can feel a little stuck. If you understand this podcast, you're already at least at the intermediate level. You're able to understand simple texts or talk about basic subjects: family, work, what you do in your spare time. In Europe, this level corresponds to B1 or even B2.

[00:08:29] But perhaps you don't yet feel at ease. “Se sentir à l'aise” means not having difficulty doing something, doing it easily. For example, if I say “je suis à l'aise en anglais,” it means I don't have any trouble speaking English. Be careful not to say “confortable.” A person can't be “confortable.” A sofa, a bed or an armchair can be comfortable, but a person can't, unless you like sitting or lying on them!

[00:09:16] So how can you feel at ease in French? That's more or less the question. When you move from the intermediate level to the advanced level, you become at ease with the language. You become able to speak the language fluently, without having to think things through. That's many people's goal: to be able to speak naturally with French speakers without searching for words, and to understand what they say to us. Unfortunately, it's easier said than done!

[00:10:00] It's a process that can take more or less time depending on the person. For some, it's very quick. For example, some people are used to learning foreign languages and are rather extroverted. For them, speaking a new language is something quite natural that they do quickly. For others, it takes more time. If you're introverted, perhaps speaking French scares you a little. You think a lot about what you want to say, you search for words, it seems difficult. That's normal; you mustn't get discouraged. You need to spend time with the language, use it in different contexts. If you're patient, little by little you'll make progress. And one day, you'll realise, you'll notice, that you've become able to speak French. Everyone can do it! In fact, in France we have a saying: “impossible n'est pas français,” literally, “impossible isn't French.” In other words, nothing is impossible.

[00:11:31] So, to help you on your adventure with French, I've prepared eight tips. The eight things that seem most important to me for successfully learning this language. Perhaps some will seem obvious to you, but I hope others will be useful.

[00:11:57] Grab a pen and a sheet of paper to take a few notes. Come on, let's get started!

### 1) Set yourself goals

[00:12:12] In your opinion, what's the first thing to do when learning a new language? Generally, we don't always know where to start. Some people buy a grammar book; others learn vocabulary lists. But if you do that, you're going to waste your time. Because the most important thing when you start is knowing where you're going, and that means having goals. OK, you probably already have a goal like “speak French fluently.” Unfortunately, that kind of goal is too general.

[00:13:00] You need more specific goals that you can achieve quickly. For example, being able to book a table at a restaurant, being able to tell the story of your favourite TV series. These are concrete goals that you can measure; you can know whether you've succeeded or not. You must also set a deadline, for example within two weeks or before your next holiday in France. Once you have these goals, you can choose a strategy for achieving them: which vocabulary words you're going to learn, which structures you need.

[00:13:59] And above all, thanks to these goals, you'll see that you're making progress, that you're able to do more and more things in French. That will motivate you and give you confidence in yourself.

### 2) Move forward little by little

[00:14:24] Next, I advise you to do things gradually. Don't choose goals that are too complicated, like explaining the political situation in your country if you can't talk about your last holiday, for example. If you choose goals that are too difficult, too ambitious, you'll get discouraged if you don't achieve them. So it's better to increase the difficulty gradually to stay motivated.

[00:15:06] Ideally, you can plan your progress in advance. Write a list of things you want to be able to do, and rank them from easiest to hardest. Obviously, you'll start with the easiest goals.

### 3) Be patient

[00:15:38] That brings me to my third tip: be patient. Now all the apps and language gurus promise that you can learn to speak a language fluently in three months. Well, yes, it's possible, but only if you're already used to learning foreign languages and, above all, if you can spend eight hours a day doing it. Personally, I don't know many people who can find eight hours a day to learn a language for three months.

[00:16:24] That means that, for most of us, we need to be patient. There's no magic formula or shortcut: to learn a language, we have to spend as much time with it as possible. And above all, we need to give ourselves time, not be impatient, because that creates frustration and we risk giving up.

### 4) Create a habit

[00:16:59] How can you make sure you spend enough time with a language? Quite simply, by creating a new habit. If you programme your brain, learning can become automatic and unconscious.

[00:17:20] To do that, you can choose a time that you'll devote to learning French every day. You can get up earlier to do it, or eliminate another activity. Often, the problem isn't time, but priorities. If learning French is your priority, you'll find time every day.

[00:17:51] Another way to create a habit is to associate French with other activities you already do. For example, listen to a podcast or a radio programme when you're going to work, going to exercise, or when you're cooking. Replace the book you read before going to sleep with a French novel or magazine.

[00:18:21] In short, if you manage to create this habit, I guarantee you'll quickly make enormous progress. By the way, I recommend listening, or listening again, to podcast number 16 about habits, so you'll understand everything about how they work.

### 5) Immerse yourself in the language

[00:18:52] We come to the fifth tip: immersion. In addition to this habit, you must try to immerse yourself in the language, to be “immersed.” Like when you dive into the sea or a swimming pool and you're underwater. Careful: here I'm not talking about diving into a French swimming pool, but about surrounding yourself with the language.

[00:19:23] In practical terms, what can you do? You can set your phone and computer to French, read, watch or listen to the news in French-language media. You can even download apps to receive notifications on your phone all day long. You can make playlists of French songs, and so on. I have students who listen to a lot of French music, and it helps them memorise expressions.

[00:20:05] In short, even if you don't have the opportunity to spend time in a French-speaking country, you'll feel as though you hear and see the language everywhere around you!

### 6) Do things you enjoy

[00:20:26] Now the sixth tip: do 50 grammar exercises every day... OK, I'm kidding, it's a joke, don't worry. If you've been listening to this podcast for a while, you know that, for me, grammar isn't the most important thing.

[00:20:50] I imagine you don't feel like getting up 30 minutes earlier to do grammar exercises, and I understand you! I don't do it either! But why not replace grammar exercises with an episode of a French series or an article on a subject you're passionate about?

[00:21:19] In other words, do things you enjoy, things that interest you. If you love cinema, you can watch films in French, but also read books about your favourite directors, find a podcast about the latest releases, and even publish reviews on film lovers' forums! There are no limits; you just need to find the right resources.

[00:21:52] That way, your practice will become natural. You'll no longer feel as though you're just “doing French,” but that you're using French for concrete activities you enjoy.

### 7) Step outside your comfort zone

[00:22:14] OK, the second-to-last tip, tip number seven. It's about the comfort zone.

[00:22:24] If you understand 80% of my podcast or more, well done! I know it's very pleasant to listen to a native speaker talking and understand everything they're saying. Our brain doesn't need to work too hard; we can just relax and enjoy it.

[00:22:47] But I also imagine that, when you watch a French film or try to listen to the radio, it's not as easy! You wonder why French people speak so fast; perhaps sometimes you feel they're speaking another language. In short, it's very difficult!

[00:23:11] Yes, but that's how you make progress. You have to put yourself in challenging situations, step outside your comfort zone. You need to feel that your brain is working, that it's making an effort. To do that, you can look for another podcast on a subject that interests you, but one made for French people rather than foreigners. A podcast that isn't too long, five to ten minutes, and that you'll listen to several times. If at first you feel you don't understand anything, that's OK! Make yourself listen to it three, five or ten times, and I promise you'll understand more and more things.

[00:24:08] So do things you enjoy, but also other, more difficult things in order to make progress.

### 8) Get a coach

[00:24:24] I know it can be difficult to keep challenging yourself, practise French regularly and stay motivated. That's why my last tip is to find a private teacher, or at least a native-speaking language partner, to help you. You can make a lot of progress on your own, but sometimes you may feel lost and need help.

[00:24:59] With my students, we choose goals together and build a tailored programme. That way, they're really motivated because we're working to achieve the goal they've set themselves, that they've chosen.

[00:25:18] But as a coach, above all I try to give them confidence in themselves, to show them that they're able to say a lot of things even with a limited vocabulary. Often, that's the biggest problem: lack of self-confidence. We're afraid of making mistakes, of not having good pronunciation. I show my students that they can communicate, get their ideas across, one way or another. It doesn't matter if their grammar isn't perfect at first, because if they love French and spend enough time with the language, one day they'll be able to speak it without difficulty. My goal is for that day to come quickly, for my students to become independent quickly and no longer need me.

**[NB: I no longer offer coaching/private lessons because I no longer have enough time.]**

[00:26:28] There you go, that was my eighth and final tip. I hope you found them useful and that they gave you a few ideas for making progress in French.

[00:26:41] If you feel you're stuck, send me an email and I'll suggest some solutions. I'll be very happy to help you!

[00:26:53] One last thing before ending this podcast. I've created a short document, a little guide, with ten great resources I recommend for intermediate learners. Websites, YouTube channels, audiobooks, podcasts other than mine, and all of it is free. You can download it for free on my website, innerfrench.com. You just need to sign up. Then you'll receive an email with this guide. So if you're interested, go and have a look on my website to find it.

[00:27:45] OK, that's all for today.

[00:27:48] Thank you very much for listening, and for being more and more numerous in doing so. I'll see you next week for a new episode. See you soon!